📚 TEACHER PROFESSIONAL LEARNING · ALL YEAR LEVELS

Teacher Professional Learning Notes

Background reading, research base, first aid currency guidance, and professional learning pathways for teachers delivering the Swim & Water Safety unit.

All year levels | Teacher reference | Research-based | PL guidance

📊 The Evidence Base — Why This Unit Matters

Key finding: Drowning is preventable. The evidence is clear that water safety education, when delivered well and connected to real-world application, saves lives. You are not teaching a compliance exercise — you are delivering content with direct life-or-death relevance.

54
Victorian drowning deaths in 2024–25 — above the ten-year average

73%
of Victorian drowning deaths were male in 2024–25

40%
of Victorian drowning deaths involved CALD community members (~28% of population)

0
drowning deaths at patrolled locations in 2024–25

300,000
global drowning deaths annually — 92% in low- and middle-income countries (WHO 2024)

4 min
window for bystander CPR before significant irreversible brain damage occurs

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📖 What the Research Tells Us About Effective Water Safety Education

- **Why awareness campaigns under-perform: Interviews with 23 Australian males aged 18–30 who drank alcohol around water found they already knew it raised their risk, but believed they could judge their own intoxication, the conditions and their swimming ability. They described others who do the same as reckless, and themselves as sensible. The researchers name optimism bias, masculine norms and peer dynamics as the drivers — so campaigns that simply restate the risk are solving a problem that does not exist (Smith et al. 2025, in LSV Aquatic Injury Prevention Agenda 2026–27). Swim ability alone is insufficient:** Most Victorian adult drowning victims could swim. The primary risk factors are situational and behavioural — swimming at unpatrolled locations, alcohol, risk-taking — not inability to swim. Education must address decision-making, not only skills.
- **Early intervention is most effective:** International evidence consistently shows that water safety education in primary and early secondary school produces better long-term behaviour change than adult education. The Year 7–8 unit targets the optimal age window.
- **Real-world application improves retention:** Scenario-based learning (as used in the scenario card activities) produces significantly better recall and application than didactic content delivery. Students who work through realistic scenarios are better prepared to act in real emergencies.
- **Family engagement amplifies impact:** Students whose families are engaged in water safety conversations at home are more likely to apply safety behaviours. This is the rationale for the parent information sheets.
- **Structural barriers require structural solutions:** Research into CALD drowning disproportionality consistently points to access barriers, not attitudinal factors. Education-only approaches are insufficient — community swim programs and multilingual communication are essential complements.

Sources: LSV Victorian Drowning Report 2023–24 | RLSSA National Drowning Report | WHO Drowning Prevention: A Guide to Implementing Recommendations | Bugeja et al. (2018) — aquatic supervision and drowning prevention

🧠 Teacher Content Knowledge — Key Concepts

🌊 What Every Teacher Delivering This Unit Should Know

You do not need to be an expert swimmer or a first aid professional to teach this unit effectively. However, confidence with the following concepts will significantly improve your delivery:

- **The 5 SwimSafe rules** — Read signs; Enter feet first; Stay in depth; Swim with a friend; Signal for help (these are on Poster 4 in the Classroom Poster Pack)
- **Beach flag system** — Red/yellow (safe zone), single red (danger), orange windsock (offshore wind/no inflatables), purple (marine danger). **The most commonly tested content across both year levels.**
- **DRS ABCD in order** — Danger, Response, Send (000), Airway, Breathing, CPR, Defibrillation. Be fluent in this — students will ask you to confirm it.
- **CPR ratio and rate** — 30 compressions : 2 breaths. Rate: 100–120 bpm (the tempo of "Stayin' Alive"). Depth: 5–6cm for adults. Allow full chest recoil.
- **Rip current escape** — Float, stay calm, swim PARALLEL to shore (not back toward shore), angle back when clear of the rip, raise one arm to signal.
- **Throw, Don't Go** — Never enter the water to rescue unless trained. Panicking drowning persons can pull untrained rescuers under. Throw first.
- **The 4-minute CPR window** — Brain cells begin dying irreversibly after 4–6 minutes without oxygenated blood. Bystander CPR within 4 minutes dramatically improves survival outcomes.

⚠️ Common student misconceptions to address proactively:

- "If you can swim, you're safe" — false. Most Victorian drowning victims could swim.
- "The water looks calm, so it's safe" — false. Rip currents and cold water shock are invisible surface hazards.
- "You should swim hard against a rip to get back to shore" — dangerous. This causes exhaustion and drowning.
- "CPR always works" — not always, but bystander CPR significantly improves survival odds and should always be attempted.
- "Someone else will call 000" — the bystander effect. Students must understand why direct, named instruction ("You — call 000") is essential.

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🦴 Diving & Spinal Injury — What Every Teacher Delivering Year 9–10 Should Know

The addition of Section 6 to the Year 9–10 workbook requires teachers to be confident with spinal injury content. The following is the minimum content knowledge required to deliver Lesson 5 effectively and respond accurately to student questions.

The physiological mechanism

When a person dives head-first into water that is shallower than expected, the force of impact travels upward through the arms and shoulders into the cervical vertebrae (C1–C7). The sudden compressive force can fracture or dislocate the vertebrae — particularly at C4–C6 — compressing or severing the spinal cord. Because spinal cord neurons cannot regenerate, the resulting loss of motor and sensory function is typically permanent. This is why quadriplegia (paralysis of all four limbs) is the most common severe outcome.

The Australian data (required for classroom delivery)

- Unsafe diving = **10%** of all spinal cord injuries and **20%** of quadriplegia cases in Australia (AIHW)
- **95%** of aquatic spinal injury patients are male — **75%+** are under 30
- Highest incidence age group: **10–14 years** — directly relevant to Year 7–8 students
- **66%** of patients suffer permanent disability
- Post-COVID: drowning among 15–20 year olds increased by **+34%** (RLSSA)

The three 2024–25 case studies

You should be familiar with all three before teaching Lesson 5: **Terrigal Wharf (NSW 2025)** — teenage boy, unknown depth under wharf structure; **Torquay Front Beach (Vic 2025)** — teenage boy, shifting sandbank at surf beach; **Bawley Beach jetty (NSW 2024)** — young man, sandbank formed between visits (false confidence). Each illustrates a different mechanism of depth change. The Bawley case is particularly important for the false confidence concept.

Addressing the "but they should have known better" response

Students frequently explain these incidents with individual blame ("they were stupid / reckless"). The pedagogical goal of Section 6 is to move students beyond this to a structural analysis: false confidence is created by an information environment that fails to communicate that depth changes. The prevention implication is structural (better signage, local hazard communication, social norm change) — not just individual education.

Recommended reading before teaching this section

- AIHW Aquatic Injury data: **aihw.gov.au** (search "aquatic injury" or "spinal cord injury")
- Royal Life Saving Australia spinal injury resources: **royallifesaving.com.au**

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- LSV Feet First campaign resources and inland waterway safety: **lsv.com.au**

🩺 First Aid Currency — Teacher Requirements

✅ What First Aid Training Do I Need?

Victorian Department of Education policy requires teachers supervising swimming and water-based activities to hold current first aid certification. Specific requirements vary by activity type:

Activity	Required certification	Renewal period
Classroom water safety theory lessons	No formal first aid requirement — standard teacher training applies	—
School swimming carnival (teacher supervisor)	Current first aid certificate (HLTAID011 or equivalent). At least one qualified first aider on site.	3 years (skills check annually recommended)
Pool-based practical sessions (on school premises)	Current first aid certificate. Check your school's policy — some schools require a lifeguard present.	3 years
Water-based excursion (off-site)	Current first aid certificate. DE Excursion Policy and Swimming Policy requirements apply. See Excursion Risk Management Template.	3 years

Always verify current DE requirements before excursions: www2.education.vic.gov.au/pal/swimming-instruction-and-water-safety-education/policy

💡 **Renewal tip:** St John Ambulance Victoria and Australian Red Cross both offer low-cost first aid renewal courses, including online theory components. Courses typically take 6–8 hours and cost approximately $70–$100. Book at stjohnvic.com.au or redcross.org.au/first-aid.

🎓 Professional Learning Pathways

🏄 LSV Teacher Professional Development

Life Saving Victoria offers professional development programs for HPE teachers covering water safety education, beach safety, and aquatic supervision. Programs are free or low-cost for Victorian schools.

lsv.com.au/education

🎖️ AUSTSWIM Qualifications

AUSTSWIM provides nationally recognised qualifications for swimming and water safety instruction. The Teacher of Swimming and Water Safety (TSWS) qualification directly supports delivery of VC2HP8M01 and VC2HP10M01.

austswim.com.au

📊 RLSSA Research & Resources

Royal Life Saving Society Australia publishes an annual National Drowning Report and evidence briefs that inform this resource suite. The RLSSA website also provides free school education resources.

royallifesaving.com.au/research

🩺 First Aid Currency

Maintain current HLTAID011 (Provide First Aid) certification. Annual CPR refresher (HLTAID009) is strongly recommended for teachers running pool sessions. St John Ambulance Victoria offers flexible delivery.

stjohnvic.com.au/first-aid-courses/

🌏 Multicultural Safety Awareness

LSV's multicultural safety team offers professional learning for teachers in culturally responsive water safety education. Particularly valuable for schools with high CALD enrolments.

lsv.com.au/community/multicultural-safety/

🌿 First Nations Cultural Competency

Reconciliation Australia's online cultural learning resources and AIATSIS provide guidance for teachers embedding First Nations perspectives into HPE curriculum contexts.

reconciliation.org.au/schools/

❓ Frequently Asked Questions

❓ "I'm not a water safety specialist. Am I qualified to teach this unit?"

Yes. This resource suite is designed to be delivered by any qualified HPE teacher. The teacher guides provide complete lesson plans, answer keys, and background notes. You do not need specialist water safety qualifications to deliver the theory and scenario-based content. For practical pool sessions, ensure your first aid certification is current and that adequate supervision is in place.

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❓ "My school doesn't have a pool. Can I still teach the practical component?"

Yes, with modification. The classroom-based scenario activities, scenario cards, DRS ABCD practice (on a mat with mannequins), and CPR practise can all be conducted without a pool. For the swimming skills component (VC2HP8M01/162), consider: (a) booking community pool time for 1–2 sessions; (b) partnering with a local LSV club for a beach safety session; or (c) adapting the practical assessment to focus on first aid skills and throw-rescue technique, which can be practised on dry land.

❓ "A student in my class has had a near-drowning experience. How do I handle this sensitively?"

This is an important consideration. Before teaching this unit, check with your wellbeing team about whether any students may have experienced a drowning-related trauma. If so: speak with the student and their family before the unit begins; offer opt-out options for specific activities (particularly scenario 3, "Not Moving"); ensure the student has access to wellbeing support; and frame the unit as empowering rather than fear-based. The goal is to build confidence and competence, not to dwell on tragedy.

❓ "How should I handle the cultural content around First Nations waterways?"

With care, respect, and humility. You do not need to be an expert in First Nations cultures to integrate this content respectfully. The Cultural Considerations resource in this suite provides detailed guidance. Key principles: name Traditional Custodians for local waterways; frame Indigenous knowledge as complementary to, not subordinate to, Western safety frameworks; do not require First Nations students to speak on behalf of all First Nations peoples; and approach the subject with genuine curiosity rather than as a compliance exercise.

💭 Professional Reflection Prompts

Am I confident in my own knowledge of DRS ABCD, beach flags, and rip current escape? If not, which resources in this suite should I review first?

Is my first aid certification current? When is my next renewal due?

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Do I know whether any students in this cohort have had water-related trauma that requires me to modify delivery?

Have I engaged with the Cultural Considerations resource and do I feel confident naming the Traditional Custodians of the relevant waterways for my students?

Am I framing CALD drowning over-representation as a structural inequity — or is my language inadvertently implying cultural deficit?

Is there a professional learning opportunity (LSV PD, AUSTSWIM course, first aid refresher) that would increase my confidence in delivering this unit?

Swim & Water Safety — Teacher Professional Learning Notes · All Year Levels · Victorian Curriculum F–10 Version 2.0

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